BOOK CLUB EXPRESS

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The Wedding People

by Alison Espach

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Discussion Questions

1. Let's start with Phoebe at the beginning of the story. She is broken and plans to commit suicide at the hotel. First, were you surprised at the dark tone that started the novel?

2. Why did Phoebe choose this particular hotel?

3. Phoebe's plans are forever altered when there's a wedding being held at the hotel. Let's talk about the first encounter between Phoebe and Lila, the bride. Why do you think they both were instantly so honest with each other?

4. As Phoebe learns more about the interesting interactions that are taking place at the hotel, she starts to reconsider her plans to end her life. What were your thoughts as this scene unfolded?

5. Phoebe goes to the hot tub, and meets a man there who she instantly connects with. Despite being shy and reserved in the past, she is upfront about what she wants from him. Why do you think Phoebe start to shed her reserved nature and become more outspoken?

6. The man is actually Gary, the groom who is set to marry Lila. What was your impression of Gary? And what was behind the connection between Phoebe and him? In what ways are they similar?

7. The story features plenty of flashbacks as we learn that Phoebe's ex-husband Matt cheated on her with a colleague, and initiated the divorce. Why was it important for the reader to read these flashbacks?

8. In what ways was Phoebe holding herself back with her relationship with Matt, and even in her career?

9. Phoebe hoped to become a mother, but it wasn't in the cards for her, at least to have a biological child. Let's talk about how this revelation impacted both Phoebe and her relationship with Matt.

10. What did you think about the other cast of characters, including Juice (Gary's daughter), Marla (Gary's sister), and Jim (Gary's best friend, and brother of Gary's first wife who passed away)?

11. The novel covers grief quite a bit. From Phoebe grieving the end of her marriage and not becoming a biological mother to Gary and Juice's grief of losing a wife and mother. How do you feel the novel handled grief, and moving forward?

Author Interview

Q & A with New York Times best-selling author Alison Espach
By G. Wayne Miller October 7, 2024

Alison, congratulations on the recent publication of your latest book, The Wedding People, set in Newport, which became an instant New York Times bestseller (description is at the end of this interview).

How long did it take to write?

The book took about four or five years, from start to finish.

What was the inspiration?

There were a few sources of inspiration, but working at weddings was a big inspiration for the perspective of Phoebe. I spent a lot of time working many weddings, where I looked on as a total stranger. Sometimes people talked to me, and I got a very honest look into the wedding. I wanted that perspective to be the guiding perspective of this book – the stranger's.

The Today Show's Jenna Bush Hager chose The Wedding People as her August 2024 Read With Jenna pick – and you went to New York to appear with her on air. Tell us about that appearance please.

It was a truly wonderful experience. I was, of course, very nervous and excited to go on the Today Show. Jenna and Hoda made it so fun and easy to be on. It wasn't an experience I expected to ever have, so the whole thing just felt like a gift.

The book received rave reviews from Publishers Weekly, The Washington Post, The New York Times Book Review, People, Booklist and a host of other top-notch publications. Did you expect such acclaim?

I try never to expect anything when I publish a book. It's always a miracle to me that people other than my friends and family read my fiction. Though this is my third book, the fact of other people responding to it never gets old. Especially to have people that I respect review it favorably – that is something I don't expect but happily celebrate.

TriStar Pictures has acquired the rights to The Wedding People. Another exciting development! Can you share any details about the production?

There aren't too many details to be shared at the moment, unfortunately. Nicole Holofcener is currently working on the script, and so we are waiting to see what she does with it before we move forward in any other way. I'm really looking forward to reading it.

Let's learn about some of your other books, starting with Notes on Your Sudden Disappearance, a novel. Brief summary please.

Notes is a novel about a young girl who chronicles her life and romantic history after her older sister dies. It's a story of how we move on after loss and the surprising connections that can be forged in the wake of grief.

Same with The Adults, a novel.

The Adults is a story about a young girl who struggles to come of age, primarily due to a relationship that begins with an older man.

And In-Depth Market Research Interviews with Dead People: Bounty, an Audible original short story, one in a series.

This is a short story series about a market research team that contacts the dead in order to do customer research with deceased customers on certain products. It's a funny and absurd series that I had a lot of fun writing.

As an author of horror short stories and books (and also non-fiction), I am a big fan of Stephen King. Asked where he gets his ideas, he once famously (and facetiously) said: Utica. Same question to you: Where do you get your ideas?

Usually some kind of scenario gets stuck in my head and I run with it. I'm honestly not sure where that comes from, other than a life spent observing others around me and making note of moments that interest me the most.

Let's learn some of your background, including when you first began writing fiction and whether you had any mentors along the way.

I started writing from a very young age – generally tried writing a novel every year. They started very small (five pages!) and ended up much larger, of course. So many people supported me on the way – my parents, high school English teachers, creative writing professors in college and graduate school. And of course my editors at Scribner and Holt who taught me so much in the last ten years.

Tell us a bit about craft: when and where you write, on screen or on paper, do you outline, when do endings come to you, etc.

I write on a computer for the most part. I don't really outline in the start, not in a typical sense, though at some point during the novel, I do have to sit down and write an outline to figure out what story I'm telling. I usually have a voice or an idea that gives me momentum and once that momentum runs out, I need to get organized.

In addition to being an author, you are a writing professor at Providence College. Your students are lucky to have you. What lessons do you impart on them?

I try to help them believe in themselves as writers and try to get them to see that their biggest strength is being themselves. So often we try to imitate others as we grow up, but eventually it's important to realize that the reason people will want to read your work is because you're you, and not someone else.

And what do you learn from them?

I remember to read and write for fun. That's the only reason they're in my class, and it's always a good reminder for me.

Can you give us a hint of what you're working on now?

I'm working on my fourth novel, but too early to say what it's about. Stay tuned!

Author Biography

Alison Espach is the New York Times best-selling author of The Wedding People, a New York Times Editor's Choice, a TODAY Show #ReadwithJenna Book Club pick, a Barnes and Noble Book Club Pick, and the #1 Indie Next Pick for August 2024. The Wedding People will be published in over twenty countries. She is also the author of Notes on Your Sudden Disappearance, a Chicago Tribune and NPR "Best Book of 2022," as well as The Adults, a New York Times Editor's Choice and Barnes and Noble Discover pick. Her fictional audio series In-Depth Market Research Interviews with Dead People is an Audible Original. She has written for McSweeney's, Vogue, Outside, LitHub, Joyland and other places. She lives and teaches creative writing in Rhode Island.

Alison received her MFA from Washington University in St. Louis. She has been a writer-in-residence at the Ucross Foundation for the Arts, Millay Arts, The Wassaic Project, the Cuttyhunk Writers Residency and the San Miguel Literary Sala.

https://www.alisonespach.com/bio

Reviews

Humor and Sentiment Join Hands in “The Wedding People”

by Ian MacAllen July 30, 2024

The rich-people-have-a-wedding plot is not a new device. Some recent standouts in the genre include Grant Ginder’s The People We Hate at the Wedding, Diksha Basu’s Destination Wedding and Sloane Crosley’s The Clasp, or the somewhat lighter novels in the Crazy Rich Asians series from Kevin Kwan. Weddings are naturally filled with drama, and even the ones that run smoothly and where everyone ends up married to the intended people often have drama. Alison Espach’s new novel, The Wedding People, is no exception, delivering a messy entanglement dappled with wry wit and occasional misfortune.

Set in the once glitzy, old-money Newport, Rhode Island, The Wedding People unfolds during the a week-long celebration for Lila, a young heiress, and Gary, a widow and doctor who treated his bride’s father for cancer before his death. The recently divorced Phoebe, who knows neither the bride, nor groom, has booked the lone vacant room in the hotel arriving as the party guests begin checking in.

The novel opens with Phoebe arriving at the hotel. She is an academic who’s research, ironically, focuses on British marriage plot novels. She has chosen this hotel to kill herself using the cat painkillers from her dead cat. Bridezilla Lila meets Phoebe in the lobby. Lila is passing out chocolate wine, a wedding favor for the guests. Lila realizes Phoebe is not a wedding guest, and this fact upsets her since all the hotel guests were supposed to have been here for her, and then even more upset when she learns of Phoebe’s plan to commit suicide. Lila convinces Phoebe to stay alive; a body would ruin her wedding week. Soon after, Phoebe is drafted to serve as Lila’s maid of honor. The novel unfolds over the week leading to Lila’s wedding.

The novel is filled with playful, comedic bits. Often these reappear, such as the case with the coconut pillows. When Phoebe arrives at the hotel, Pauline, the hotel manager, offers her a coconut pillow. The pillow is particularly soft and scented like coconut, with the scent of coconut intended to bring comfort to the sleeper. Phoebe is not comforted, but Lila, on the other hand, finds the coconut pillows a necessary luxury. The coconut pillow resurfaces over the course of the novel with various characters offering opinions. The whole concept of the coconut pillow seems like such a perfect parody, I dared research their existence, and was shocked to learn they are a real product.

But these details layer an absurdity on top of the novel’s plot, providing the book a certain necessary levity. It’s a reminder the book is playful as much as it is literary. Espach speckles her wry humor throughout the novel, from the cat painkillers to the environmentally friendly penis straws, helping to offset the slow building of the novel’s plot.

While the opening of the novel is hurried and impactful, the pacing in the middle of the novel struggles to some degree. Phoebe's arrival in Newport is punchy, with a hint of a mystery to help crank up the tension: "when she left St. Louis, it felt important to leave everything behind—the husband, the house, the luggage." Espach leads us to have more questions than answers, drawing us into her world, to the character of Phoebe.

Phoebe has two main problems that are revealed early in the text to explain her desire to chase her cat's pain pills with chocolate wine—she has struggled with infertility, and then her husband had an affair. Immediately she is sympathetic, and her tough honesty is refreshing. The plot moves quickly in these opening pages, particularly as she befriends Lila.

In part because Phoebe has nothing left to lose, she is absolutely honest, to the point of being cold. She tells Lila about a piece of food stuck in her teeth—another recurring gag—and this helps Lila feel a sentimentality towards Phoebe. But Phoebe's behavior also charms the reader and makes us want to spend time with her. Espach's opening here is delightfully enticing.

However, the narrative slows considerably once Phoebe has been drafted to serve as Lila's only friend. The pace slows as Phoebe's backstory is revealed. Her struggle with becoming pregnant, her relationship with her ex-husband Matt, her relationship with the academic department, with Matt's girlfriend, and her career all provide an explanation, a defense of her desire to end her life, and to document her choice to live. But rehashing Phoebe's past, while perhaps necessary to fully build out her character, takes away from the forward momentum of the present.

As readers, we're pulled along on the journey of this destination wedding, but the endless parties begin to drag on. No doubt there are wedding events of this magnitude, but even a long weekend wedding can feel, in the moment, to be interminable.
However, there's good reason for the detailed experience of Lila's wedding week. This wedding is filled with many moving parts. The slower pace of the narrative provides space for rich character development. Gary's daughter, Juice, is acting out at the prospect of a step mother. Gary's best friend Jim is also his dead wife's brother. Lila, Jim, and Gary all have a shared history revealed to us during the course of the novel, adding to the intrigue. There's also a nude painting of Lila's mother that is passed around, commented on, and eventually becomes an important plot point. All of these characters have their own motivations, and Espach has committed to developing them all into fully formed characters. However, crafting their stories consumes the forward momentum of the plot.

The plodding story creates a solid foundation for the overlapping love triangles, the plot wound tight as information is teased out. The payoff for the grind is the release of the tension over the course of the rehearsal dinner and the wedding day. At the end, Espach returns to the harried pace of the opening pages. The effort building the plot is unleashed as each loose end is tied together with an anxious conclusion.

In The Wedding People, Espach has crafted a modern version of the British marriage plot novel, a complex twisted story of sadness and love tied together neatly in an old manor house. Comedic, entertaining, and occasionally unexpected, The Wedding People is the ideal plus one for a destination wedding.

Ian MacAllen is the author of Red Sauce: How Italian Food Became American, forthcoming from Rowman & Littlefield in 2022. His writing has appeared in Chicago Review of Books, The Rumpus, The Offing, Electric Literature, Vol 1. Brooklyn, and elsewhere. He serves as the Deputy Editor of The Rumpus, holds an MA in English from Rutgers University, tweets @IanMacAllen and is online at IanMacAllen.com.

https://chireviewofbooks.com/2024/07/30/humor-and-sentiment-join-hands-in-the-wedding-people/

Read-Alikes

The Guncle by Steven Rowley
When Patrick, or Gay Uncle Patrick (GUP) for short, takes on the role of primary guardian for his young niece and nephew, he sets “Guncle Rules,” but soon learns that parenting isn’t solved with treats or jokes as his eyes are opened to a new sense of responsibility. While The Guncle is set over a summer in Palm Springs and The Wedding People takes place at a Newport, Rhode Island hotel during a week of wedding festivities, both warm and witty novels follow main characters dealing with great loss.

Down with the Shipmans by Meg Mitchell Moore

It's the week after Fourth of July, and the Shipman sisters are returning to their picturesque summer home on the New Hampshire coast for what they believe is a family reunion, the first without their late mother. However, their tranquil setting quickly becomes a stage for drama when their father, Calvin, drops the bombshell news that he plans to sell the cherished beach house. As old memories are stirred up, the sisters must decide how far they're willing to go to preserve the Shipman bond. This book will appeal to readers who enjoy amusing relationship fiction about life change events and exploring the theme: coping with death.

Otherwise Engaged by Susan Mallery

When Shannon gets engaged, she wants to tell her mom Cindy—who’s also engaged—but dreads a double wedding. She keeps it secret until Cindy’s vows are done. Victoria, a stuntwoman, has never fit her mother Ava’s mold. A mishap brings her home, and Ava hopes to connect. The four women meet at a wedding venue, where a secret surfaces: Cindy once chose Ava to adopt her baby—then backed out. The loss shaped Ava’s bond with Victoria. Now Shannon and Victoria must face who they are—and who they might’ve been. We think you'll like this if you're in the mood for reflective relationship fiction about weddings, loss, and life change events.